from Colachel about 40 kilometres up the west coast from Kanyakumari. This fine old structure still stands, with two palaces at its heart, one for the king and an even grander one for his mother, in line with Nair custom. A secret underground passage is said to have run from here to the fortress itself, standing on an isolated hill half a mile to the south-west. Today the fort is called the Uthayagiri Bio-Diversity Park and is under the care of the Tamil Nadu Forest Department, but its former name was Dillanai Kottai, or ‘De Lannoy’s Fort’. All but lost in the undergrowth are the remains of a small Dutch cantonment and the roofless walls of a small church. On its floor, and now guarded by iron railings, are the graves of the man who became known as Valiya Kappithaan, or the ‘Great Captain’, together with his wife and son. Topped by a coat of arms, the central gravestone carries two inscriptions, one in Tamil and one in Latin, which translates as:

STAND TRAVELLER! HERE LIES EUSTACHIUS
BENEDICTUS DE LANNOY: who was commander of the
general Travancore army and for nearly thirty-seven
years with the greatest faithfulness served the King, to
whom by the strength and fear of his armies he
subjugated all kingdoms from Kayangulam to Cochin.
He lived 62 years and 5 months and died first day of
June 1777. May he rest in peace.

Eustachius de Lannoy is very much part of Travancore’s story. Marthanda Varma gave the captured Dutch soldiers the choice of enslavement or enlistment in his army, so they duly enrolled. Their commander was thirty-four-year-old Captain de Lannoy, whose diligence in training the raja’s bodyguard led to him being given charge of the rebuilding of the defences of the old fort at Padmanabhapuram. Eventually he became joint commander of the Nair forces, who were now taught to fight with muskets and gunpowder